



SHAHNAWAZ, BENAZIR, MURTAZA, SANAM, NUSRAT AND ZULFIKAR IN ONE OF THE LAST FAMILY PHOTOGRAPHS TAKEN OF THE BHUTTOS TOGETHER; FATIMA WITH HER FATHER MURTAZA (RIGHT)



EXCERPT

As Prime Minister, Benazir made the decision to cover her head with a white *dupatta*. She was the first member of our family to wear a *hijab*. Her father, so progressive that he shunned traditional Sindhi dictates of *purdah*, the system of keeping one's womenfolk at home and behind closed doors so no unrelated male might eye them, and broke barriers by taking his wife and daughters to public gatherings along with his sons, never considered the headscarf necessary for public approval. Fatima Jinnah, the sister and companion of the nation's founder, fought elections against General Ayub Khan in the 1960s and she, an unmarried woman, never covered her hair. Benazir's choice was the first of its kind; not even her mother Nusrat covered her hair; it was a choice designed to keep the Islamic parties and leaders, like Maulana Fazlul Rehman's Jamiat e Ulema Islami—a constant election ally—on her side. Islam was an accessory at times and at others, it seems, an ideology. Benazir did not suspend the Hudood Ordinances, that called for women who commit adultery or engage in premarital sex to be put to death; nor did she enhance women's rights in any official way.

rogues, from Colonel Gaddafi to the Ba'athist tyrant Hafez Assad of Syria. Strangely, the memoirist suspends her otherwise acute sense of history when it comes to appreciating the benevolence of such men; strange because her own tragic inheritance, the core of this book, is a repudiation of such uniformed bestiality.

Maybe it's inevitable. Murtaza, at certain points in the book, looks like the Che Pakistan was not worthy of. He needed his battlefields, but he couldn't go beyond the safe houses in Kabul and Damascus. Still, *Songs of Blood and Sword* succeeds in giving him an aura of revolutionary romance. Even the women in his life—Della, wife of a jailed right-wing junta leader from Greece; his first wife Fowzia, Fatima's biological mother from Kabul; and his second wife Ghinwa, an exile from Beirut whom he met at a swimming pool in Damascus—add to the image. To sustain the heroism of Murtaza, the story requires a counter force, darker, opaque, and here it's the sister. As prime minister, Benazir would never open an investigation into the mysterious death of her brother Shahnawaz, who was poisoned in his French flat. Why? The Bhutto family advocate

in the case, a famous French lawyer, would tell Fatima one day: "Ahh well, perhaps she already knew." What she feared most was Murtaza's homecoming—the return of the warrior prince from exile to claim the throne. He would be denied the Bhutto home seat, but eventually he would win as an independent. He would come back, only to be imprisoned for treason. Freedom after eight months would turn out to be the prologue to his assassination. "The last shot, Papa's autopsy showed, was fired into his jaw at point-blank range. It was fired, forensics confirmed, by a gunman standing over him as he lay down in the police car." Years later, before her own death on the street, Fatima's *wadi* would tell an interviewer that "it was Murtaza's own fault that he was killed... Murtaza had a death wish".

Elsewhere in her memoir, Fatima Bhutto asks, "Why was everything in this family so complicated? Why was it so ugly, so violent?" She could very well have replaced the word "family" with Pakistan. The story of her ancestry is the story of the imperfections of democratic impulses in a lost country as well. And this story can only be rebutted by the dead. So truth is still elsewhere, trapped in the never ending whispers of the ghosts that swarm the political history of Pakistan. ■